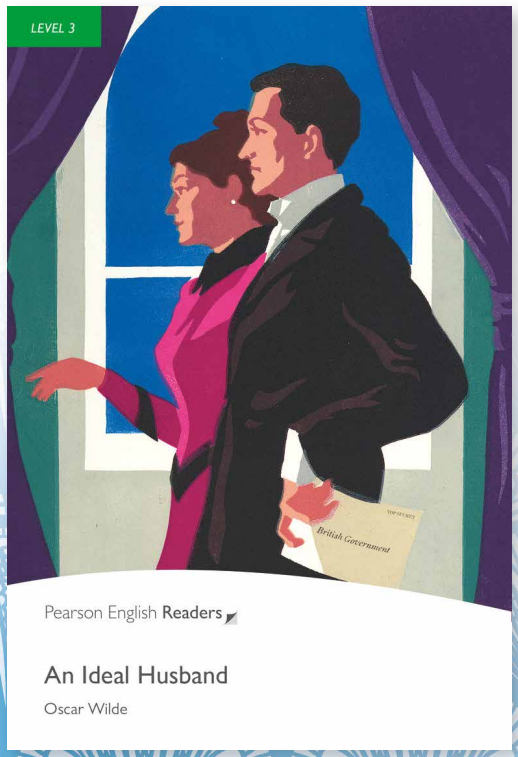
AN IDEAL HUSBAND by Oscar Wilde (A2+–B1)



PREPARATION

1 **Look at the photo of the man and woman and answer the questions.**



see

1 What are the two people doing?

think

2 Is it good to have secrets?

3 Are you good at keeping a secret?

4 What kinds of secrets should you **not** keep?

wonder

5 How do the people in the photo feel?

6 What kind of secret could they be talking about?

7 What kinds of secrets give people power over other people?

Sir Robert's secret

Mrs Cheveley: [*sitting back in her chair*]: Gertrude, I know you do not like me. And I have always hated you. But I have come here to help you.

Lady Chiltern: [*angrily*]: As you wanted to help my husband last night? But I saved him from that.

Mrs Cheveley: [*standing up quickly*]: You told him to break his promise to me!

Lady Chiltern: Yes.

Mrs Cheveley: Then you must tell him to keep it. Tomorrow, he must help me with this great plan.

Lady Chiltern: This **dishonest** plan.

Mrs Cheveley: You can call it what you like. I have great power over your husband. You must tell him to help me.

Lady Chiltern: [*standing up and going towards her*]: You're a very **rude** woman. My husband will not talk to you.

Mrs Cheveley: [*coldly*]: In this world we often meet people who are the same as us. Your husband and I are dishonest. You and he are very different. But he and I are closer than friends. We are enemies who have made the same mistakes.

Lady Chiltern: Don't say that my husband is like you! And don't tell us what to do! Leave my house!

[*Sir Robert comes in. He hears his wife's last words and he sees Mrs Cheveley. He looks very nervous.*]

Mrs Cheveley: Your house! This house was bought dishonestly. [*She turns round and sees Sir Robert.*] Ask him where his money came from! He sold a **government** secret to a businessman! Ask him about his success.

Lady Chiltern: It's not true! Robert! It's not true!

Mrs Cheveley: [*pointing her finger at him*]: Look at him! Can he answer? No, he can't!

Sir Robert: Go immediately! You have done your worst.

Mrs Cheveley: My worst? I haven't finished with you yet. You must do what I say before tomorrow at twelve o'clock. If you don't, I'll tell the world Robert Chiltern's secret.



GLOSSARY

dishonest *adj.* the opposite of honest

rude *adj.* saying things that are not polite or kind

government *n.* the people whose job is to decide what the country will do



COMPREHENSION

2 LL5.01 **Listen and read the text, then complete the summary with the words in the box. There are two extra words you do not need.**

secret	enemy	dishonest	success
power	past	promise	government

Summary

Sir Robert has made a [1] ..... to Mrs Cheveley but his wife, Lady Chiltern, has told him not to keep it. However, Mrs Cheveley knows a [2] ..... about Sir Robert's [3] ..... . Mrs Cheveley wants to use her [4] ..... over Sir Robert to make him do something [5] ..... so she can make a lot of money. She tells Lady Chiltern that she knows how her husband made a [6] ..... of his life and now she is going to tell the rest of the world.

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

3 **Some jobs mean you have to keep secrets. Find out about one of these secrets. Who keeps it and why?**

1 Area 51
2 The Hippocratic Oath
3 The Habsburg Napkin

SPEAKING

4A **Work in small groups with people who worked on different secrets. Tell your group what you know about the secret you have chosen. Listen to the stories about their secrets. Which secret would you most like to know?**

B **One place some people keep secrets is in a diary. Answer these questions.**

1 Do you keep a diary?
2 Is it ever OK to read someone's diary?
3 Where is a good place to hide a diary so no-one can read its secrets?

CLIL CONNECTION

Information technology

5 **Find out how much of your personal information is secret and how much is public. Start by logging out of all your social media accounts so you can only see what other people can see.**

1 What did you find?
2 What terms did you use to do your searches, for example, your name including middle name?
3 What do you find if you search your home address or other personal information?
4 Do the results of your search make you want to change any of your online habits?